
SURVIVING TRACE

- > identity/authenticity
- > provenance or archaeological provenience
- > date and transmission
- > author/audience/purpose/genre
- > comparison and corroboration
- > silence and alternatives
- > QUALIFIED HISTORICAL CLAIM

RULE: texts are not transparent facts; archaeology is not self-interpreting.

ARCHAEOLOGY	settlement, technology, foodways	context/sampling
EPIGRAPHY	acts, rulers, donors, institutions	formula/elite survival
NUMISMATICS	authority, metrology, circulation	hoard/movement bias
LITERATURE	norm, memory, ideas, vocabulary	genre/redaction
FOREIGN	routes, comparison, synchronism	standpoint/translation
VISUAL/ORAL	patronage, iconography, memory	convention/performance
SCIENCE	ranges, diet, mobility, environment	sample/baseline limits

NO FIXED HIERARCHY: fit the source to the question.

PREHISTORY	archaeology dominates
HARAPPAN PROTOHISTORY	c. 2600-1900 BCE; script undeciphered
VEDIC/POST-VEDIC	layered oral-textual traditions + archaeology
EARLY HISTORIC	readable inscriptions, coins, cities, many texts
3rd c. BCE	Ashokan corpus gives firm epigraphic anchors
1837	Prinsep's decisive Brahmi decipherment step
MODERN METHOD	archaeometry, bioarchaeology, digital corpora

SURVEY -> SITE -> EXCAVATION -> STRATIGRAPHY -> ASSEMBLAGE -> INTERPRETATION
vertical trench = sequence | horizontal exposure = selected phase layout
lower undisturbed layer generally earlier
BUT pits, intrusion, erosion and redeposition can disturb sequence
artefact -> industry -> assemblage -> archaeological culture
CAUTION: archaeological culture != race/language/tribe/dynasty/state

RELATIVE: stratigraphy | typology | seriation | cross-dating | palaeography
CHRONOMETRIC:
- radiocarbon -> calibrated range for organic death
- TL -> last suitable heating
- OSL -> last sufficient light exposure
- isotopes -> diet/mobility with baselines
- aDNA -> ancestry/relatedness with sample limits
RULE: result dates a sample and association, not automatically a civilisation.

EPIGRAPHY = inscriptions | PALAEOGRAPHY = old writing/scripts
Brahmi: normally left to right; parent of many later scripts
Kharoshthi: right to left; north-west/Gandhara
Ashokan corpus: mainly Prakrit-Brahmi; north-west also Kharoshthi,
Greek and Aramaic settings
1837 Prinsep: cumulative comparative decipherment, not solitary intuition

GENRES:
edict -> policy claim, not automatic implementation
prashasti -> genealogy/ideology, but eulogy and omission
land grant -> legal-fiscal act, not uniform enforcement
donation -> donor/institution, but selection and survival bias

PANEL 7/14 – COINS AND NUMISMATICS

COIN = metal + weight + manufacture + legend + icon + die + wear + context
YIELD: issuer, title, relative sequence, standard, technology, circulation
HOARD: selected deposit; latest issue supplies a post-issue boundary
OVERSTRIKE: undertype earlier than or contemporary with oertype
Jogalthembi: Nahapana undertypes counter-struck by Gautamiputra Satakarni
LIMITS: distribution != sovereignty; abundance != total prosperity;
debasement can reflect scarcity, demand or policy, not only collapse.

PANEL 8/14 – LITERARY SOURCE FAMILIES

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VEDIC          ritual, kinship, economy vocabulary | oral layers  
EPIC/PURANA    memory, values, genealogy             | recension/interpolation  
BUDDHIST/JAINA monastery, merchant, town, doctrine | sectarian/didactic frame  
SANGAM         chiefs, war, love, work, exchange      | bardic/dating issues  
DHARMASHASTRA  norm, property, family, gender                   | prescription != practice  
ARTHASHASTRA   statecraft model                                | not one-reign transcript  
COURT/BIOGRAPHY patronage, ideology, political memory | praise/aesthetic convention
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TEXTUAL TIME:

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composition -> performance -> addition/redaction -> recension  
-> surviving manuscript -> critical edition/translation -> interpretation
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PANEL 9/14 – FOREIGN, VISUAL, ORAL AND LINGUISTIC EVIDENCE

FOREIGN ACCOUNT:

route + duration + purpose + language + informants + audience
+ direct observation/hearsay + translation/survival
Megasthenes | Periplus | Faxian | Xuanzang | Arab-Persian witnesses

VISUAL/MATERIAL:

architecture, sculpture, painting, pottery, seals -> patronage, technology,
ritual and representation; image != photograph; style != exact date.

LINGUISTIC/ORAL:

loanwords, place names, genealogy, performed memory
language != race/ancestry/polity; performance reshapes memory.

PANEL 10/14 – TRIANGULATION

MATCH chronology -> geography -> scale -> independence -> source purpose

TEXT CLAIM + INSCRIPTION/COIN + ARCHAEOLOGICAL CONTEXT + SCIENTIFIC RANGE
|
v
CONVERGENCE / CONFLICT / RESIDUAL SILENCE
|
v
BOUNDED HISTORICAL INFERENCE

Pali money terms + punch-marked coins -> monetisation, regionally uneven
Sangam ports + Tamil-Brahmi + imported wares -> connectivity, not total volume
Ashokan edicts + Pataliputra + classical testimony -> complementary Mauryan views

OVER-REPRESENTED: rulers, donors, literate elites, stone, metal, monuments
UNDER-REPRESENTED: labour, women, perishable life, oral communities
SILENCE TEST: expected production? survival? recognition? adequate search?
UNPROVENANCED OBJECT: material/style may survive; contextual history is lost
FORGERY CONTROL: material, script, custody, comparison and publication
INSTITUTIONS: ASI, museums and archives preserve evidence; catalogues and
digital records remain revisable source layers.

PANEL 12/14 – WHAT SOURCES REVEAL

POLITY edicts, prashastis, grants, coins, court texts
ECONOMY settlements, workshops, coins, ports, merchant/donor records
SOCIETY houses, burials, normative texts, donations, literature
RELIGION ritual texts, monasteries, icons, donations, architecture
GENDER prescriptions + female donations + household/material evidence
ENVIRONMENT pollen, seeds, fauna, soils, isotopes, palaeochannels

RULE: one source answers one dimension; cross-reading controls elite bias.

2018 GS-I: Chinese and Arab travellers -> value + standpoint + corroboration
2023 Q46: literary attribution; local official key unavailable -> do not invent
2024 Q55: site/state/type cells; official key B (rows 2 and 3)

TRAPS:
manuscript date != composition | prashasti != neutral chronicle
coin distribution != empire | radiocarbon != exact event year
aDNA != language/caste/religion | absence != non-existence
foreign != objective | archaeology != self-explaining

1. Decode directive and historical dimension.
2. Select source class fitted to that claim.
3. Write CLAIM -> NAMED EVIDENCE -> ANALYSIS -> QUALIFICATION.
4. Add independent corroboration at matching time/place/scale.
5. State silence or residual uncertainty.
6. End with a graded verdict, not "all sources are important".

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION:

Ancient Indian history is strongest when independent archives constrain one another without erasing genre, context, survival bias or uncertainty.